Unfortunately, when the Proteas compete in an official ICC tournament, it is far from a perfect world. It is far from perfect because, whether we like it or not, whatever any of us say, we do carry the burden of history. It is far from perfect because, at any given moment, as individuals and as a team, we tend to feel strangled by the pressure and the weight of expectation, and what should be easy can suddenly feel almost impossible.

Golfers know all about the 'yips', a movement disorder that makes straightforward short putts suddenly appear terrifyingly difficult. Something seems to scramble the brain and even established professionals have been known to suffer the 'yips' and take five or six shots to get down from two or three feet from the pin. At times over the years, it has felt as though the Proteas, as a team, have experienced a kind of collective 'yips' in ICC tournaments.

Back in Centurion, I told myself to get my mind right. We needed to reach the target of 215 to beat New Zealand and remain in the 2009 ICC Champions Trophy. And for once, we did go out and get the job done. Hashim and Jacques played well, I scored an unbeaten 70 and, in a surge of relief, we eased over the line with almost nine overs to spare.

OK, we said, let's keep going. We're No. 1 in the world, we're playing at home etcetera, etcetera ... and, in a highly competitive pool, we knew we needed to beat England to reach the semifinal. They won the toss and batted first and, with Owais Shah and Eoin Morgan finding form, posted 323.

Graeme Smith led our chase heroically. Gallant and brave beyond words, he batted on when wickets kept falling around him; he batted on when he started to suffer severe cramp and was denied a runner; he batted on and on and simply refused to accept the prospect of defeat. He had moved his score to 141 from 134 balls when he fell in the 47th over ... and we fell 22 runs short, beaten by England, bundled out of our own tournament.